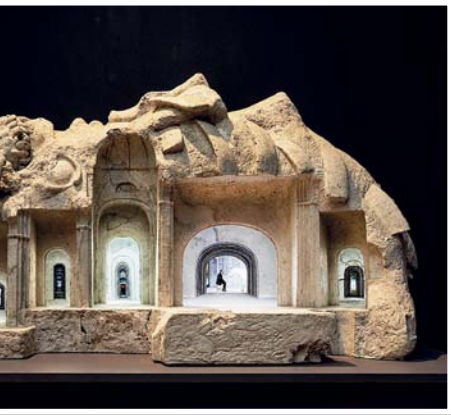






oil; in each, the press of the invisible city bends the spine of an old man—one sitting, clutching a bag or a tiffin-box at possibly a railway platform, the other on a hospital bed with his back to us, a figure somehow emaciated and bloated at the same time, his unseen face indicated vividly in the stern yet pitying gaze of the much younger nurse attending to him. While there is other lovely work in the show, just these two paintings are worth the effort of the trip.

Speaking of his langur sculptures and their intertwined tails, N.S. Harsha has mentioned that he partly got the idea from a folk tale of rats getting their tails fatally entangled. In 'Tamasha – Kiska Sunu?', four langurs adopt different poses while suspended off the wall, each animal with a similar *mudra* of a long pre-sapien finger pointing heavenwards. While their tails are interlaced, the linking seems more like an act of celebratory, seditious communication rather than of mutual entrapment. At one level, the upward pointing fingers indicate some higher being that is witness to everything. On the other hand, these beings are themselves all-seeing, all-hearing, all-talking—a cheerful, crouching cabal of simian umpires, giving out the human race for its grotesque shenanigans and sending us back to the pavilion of oblivion. Going closer, you see the nuts and bolts that hold up each sculpture, the obvious cloth ropes that make up the snaking tails, the absence of visual subterfuge creating a distancing loop of laughter and contemplation.

A similar mobius strip is created when you sit down and spend some time engaging with Ranbir Kaleka's new, 5-channel video-sculpture, 'Synaptic Visions of Dead Time'. On a platform in a darkened room is what seems to be a model of an old ruin, a cave temple of sorts, with five arched corridor-tunnels, each containing a continuation of the architecture on a small video screen. In the tiny videos, small mysterious things simultaneously unfold with what seems like an aleatory synchronicity: asteroid-like stones drop through; light changes on ancient walls; a man in a suit sits in a chair and brings down a heavy mallet, conjuring up a docile horse; in one window, a tree and sky form the sliver of a landscape from a Renaissance painting; in another window, a man rows a boat and abruptly disappears in mid-stroke; flocks of superimposed birds fly through from one window to the next, creating an obviously false continuum of space and time. It's a flick of sombre absurdity, but also a flame-lick of laughter, pushing against a dark time. ■

Ruchir Joshi

Selected works by B.V. Doshi and six other artists are on display at Delhi's Vadehra Art Gallery

DOWN TO AN ART

Must-see shows in the country



▲INSCAPES
Basist Kumar
Nature Morte, New Delhi
(Until October 29)
Though Basist Kumar's paintings seem to mimic photographs on the surface, they also defy almost all photographic convention when you look a little closer. His landscapes seem both spiritual and surreal.



▲AND WHEN SHE ROARED, THE UNIVERSE CRACKED
Various Artists
Sakshi Gallery, Mumbai
(Until October 29)
Artists like Mithu Sen, Pooja Iranna and Shakuntala Kulkarni come together in this Jesal Thacker-curated show to explore themes of performance, transition, resistance, and, in the end, reformation.



▲THE COMPULSIVE ACT
Jogen Chowdhury
Gallery Art Exposure, Kolkata
(Until December 17)
Jogen Chowdhury has now been drawing for six decades. Looking at his output, we are made witness to his sublime artistic process—that uncanny ability to make extraordinary even very ordinary things.